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Rose

April 1945

At the end of her shift, Rose went to the washhouse to meet André. It was one of their favorite spots—a secluded covered platform on the Müglitz River built with stone columns and a sloped slate roof that shielded them from prying eyes. Sunlight sparkled on the water, and purple and white crocus poked up from the banks on either side.

It had been ten months since the terrible day Reinhardt had made his proposal, forcing Rose to choose who would live or die. She'd delayed as long as possible, hoping for a year with André. In her heart, she knew there would never be room for anyone else. She needed to make this year of love last a lifetime.

She spotted him first. Running across the bank leading to the washhouse, he whistled a familiar French tune she recognized from the radio. Her gut churned a mix of emotions at the grenade she was about to launch into his world.

Something in his movements made her hesitate. It was that irresistible lightness she'd found so attractive on their first date, strolling around Place du Martroi. She felt a pang of regret and doubted her strength. Then she went through the reasons why—the aerial bombings, Katya growing fast and nearly ready to crawl at seven months, Léa and Josef in love, and André, having already lost his father, deserved to be happy with someone else. One recovers from love but not death. If letting go would keep them safe, she needed to go through with it. She forced herself onward.

He jumped onto the platform and smiled, holding out his arms. She went to him, and he brought her close, stroking her back slowly and quietly.